

The Shocking FAILURE 3 RELIEF

■ The first food packets were dropped by two helicopters only two days after some 866 villages and 335 panchayats were inundated.

■ The National Disaster Management Authority did not have adequate number of boats or personnel to handle such a crisis.

■ In Madhepura, the State Auxiliary Police that was meant to assist in relief efforts were themselves marooned because of a shortage of boats.

■ It took more than a week for the armed forces to be pressed into relief and rescue operations.

**People in
relief camps**

3 lakh

**People who
need camps**

20 lakh



“None of us have faith in the Government providing us any kind of relief.”

RAMCHANDRA PASWAN, 46

Factory worker, Tirasi Basti, Madhepura

Paswan is so traumatised that he just can't sleep. Ranju Devi and Laruan Devi, the wives of his two brothers, have been equally restless. They stand guard while their 10 starving children sleep on a tarpaulin sheet at the Saharsa railway station. They were the first batch of people who left their homes when floodwaters became ankle-deep. Paswan's father, two brothers and wife stayed back, waiting for the waters to recede. "We had decided to meet at Saharsa if at all they were to leave home," he said. It has been an endless wait though. At least 10,000 such people are at the Saharsa railway station alone, crammed cheek by jowl. Here too, they are destined to live in wretchedness, thanks to the laggard relief efforts.

breach only a day later. On August 20 Kumar did an aerial survey of the area and returned shaken, describing it as *pralaya* (catastrophe). He then appealed to the people in the region over All India Radio to evacuate. By then the raging Kosi had overflowed the embankment, creating a new course that would engulf over 800 villages in the days ahead. Tragically enough even two days after Kumar's aerial survey, relief and rescue operation had not begun in full swing.

Part of the reason for the slow response is that the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), which was set up three

years ago to handle such crisis, was far from ready. The agency is currently housed in 40 rooms in a doomed public sector hotel in Delhi. NDMA officials complain of lack of space for hosting a proper control room.

To be fair, nearly 355 men of the National Disaster Relief Force (NDRF)—the NDMA's specialised emergency teams—were the first to reach the devastated areas on August 18 with 90 new boats, even before the armed forces columns. Trained in swimming and emergency medical care, the NDRF proved to be useful when it came to rescuing people from the swirling waters. "This is the first crisis we confronted after